

Synthesis, Frontier Questions, And Student Research Designs

Gender Study — Week 10

Teaching deck draft

Central question

- What does a credible frontier research design on gender and labor markets look like?
- How do we move from a gendered labor fact to a mechanism, counterfactual, method, and contribution?
- Why should a setting-specific project be broadly interesting to labor economists?

labor object → mechanism → counterfactual → identified margin → contribution

Course recap as a research map

Block	Labor objects	Research-design question
Week 1	gaps, measurement, welfare	what outcome is being measured?
Weeks 2–3	care, fertility, skills, sorting	when and why do trajectories diverge?
Weeks 4–5	firms, authority, norms, bargaining	what is worker sorting versus treatment?
Weeks 6–7	policy, safety, mobility	who bears incidence and hidden harms?
Weeks 8–9	comparative settings, new data	what travels, and what can data see?
Optional	LGBTQ+ labor institutions	what identity object is observed?
Week 10	student research designs	what is the contribution?

Where the literature is now

- Beyond a single wage gap: households, firms, policy, safety, institutions, identity, and welfare.
- Lifecycle evidence made care, children, and dynamic careers central.
- Firm-side work opened hiring, promotions, pay-setting, networks, authority, and job design.
- Policy papers increasingly ask incidence: workers, firms, households, applicants, coworkers.
- New data reveal applications, postings, managers, time use, platform choices, climate, and identity.

What has been answered

- Children and care are central to persistent earnings, hours, and career gaps.
- Firms matter: sorting across firms and treatment within firms both shape gaps.
- Policy labels are not mechanisms; financing, compliance, take-up, and firm response matter.
- Comparative evidence is useful when it isolates mechanisms, not when it tours countries.
- Measurement is part of the estimand: legal category, self-identity, perceived identity, and disclosure differ.

Unresolved core debates and gaps

Frontier gap	Contribution margin
Firm organization	authority, evaluation, schedules, managers, low-promotability tasks
Hidden harms	safety, harassment, mobility risk, stigma, dignity, mental health
Identity measurement	LGBTQ+, trans, nonbinary, disclosure, perceived treatment, privacy
Policy incidence	firm response, applicants, households, nonparticipants, coworkers
Portability	what travels: mechanism, sign, magnitude, policy, or method?
Technology	AI exposure, monitoring, scheduling, task change, remote work

Research-design template

Step	Question
Labor object	what outcome or allocation problem is central?
Mechanism	why should gender shape the object?
Counterfactual	compared with whom, what, or when?
Labor margin	search, hiring, hours, promotion, firm sorting, safety, benefits?
Data source	what data observe the moving margin?
Identification	what variation distinguishes mechanism from selection?
Welfare object	whose income, time, risk, autonomy, authority, or dignity changes?
Contribution	what should readers update about labor economics?

Weak start

- “Gender and commuting”
- “Women in firms”
- “LGBTQ+ wage gaps”
- “Childcare policy”

Research-design start

- safety risk and search radius
- manager assignment and promotion ratings
- identity disclosure and firm sorting
- childcare access and retention at high-premium firms

The design begins when the moving labor margin is visible.

Identification threats to diagnose early

- Selection into observed work, firms, applications, surveys, or reports.
- Controls that are mechanisms: occupation, hours, tenure, firm, manager, promotion.
- Anticipation before childbirth, policy rollout, disclosure, reporting, or legal change.
- Reporting versus prevalence in complaints, harassment, safety, and climate data.
- Firm response: pay, hiring, job design, outsourcing, sorting, compliance.
- Measurement mismatch between the available category and the treatment concept.

Portability and broad-interest framing

Question	Strong answer
Why this setting?	it isolates a labor mechanism unusually clearly
What travels?	the mechanism or margin, even if levels differ
What does not travel?	local legal, cultural, sectoral, or enforcement details
Why should nonexperts care?	the result informs a broader labor-market question
What is the contribution?	work, wages, firms, households, mobility, institutions, or welfare

The setting is

leverage; the contribution is the labor mechanism.

Interdisciplinary directions

Direction	Labor question
Urban and spatial	commuting, housing, safety, childcare geography, job access
Political economy	representation, enforcement, public employment, voice, law
Health and reproduction	fertility timing, IVF, abortion access, menopause, well-being
Technology and AI	task exposure, monitoring, scheduling, remote work, platforms
Crime and safety	violence, harassment, mobility, sorting, welfare
Organizations	leadership, mentoring, culture, evaluation, authority

Project-generation guidance

- Start with one labor object.
- Choose one mechanism that could plausibly move it.
- Name the comparison group before choosing the estimator.
- Match the data to the moving margin.
- Write the main threat in one sentence.
- State what travels beyond the setting.
- End with the welfare or distributional object.

Reproduce

- build idea bank
- classify objects
- export design table

Diagnose

- score fit
- flag threats
- compare methods

Design

- pick one idea
- memo scaffold
- contribution sentence

Bridge to students' own agendas

- A good gender-and-labor project is precise about mechanism.
- It is honest about what the design identifies and what remains hidden.
- It treats local knowledge as leverage, not as the whole contribution.
- It makes welfare broader than wages when safety, time, dignity, autonomy, or authority matter.
- The goal is not to add gender to a labor topic; it is to learn labor economics through gendered mechanisms.

fact $\neq$ mechanism $\neq$ design $\neq$ contribution

Week 10 is the handoff: from course map to research agenda.